Monday Nite Footballers Commentary

NAIA: Will The Real Johnny Miller Speak Up?

By Jim Nunnelly

1972. That year makes Johnny Miller speak up. And, when he talks about that year, he smiles. He gives you a I-will-correct-you look, if he thinks you do not have the facts about 1972. Usually, Johnny Miller is a quiet, unassuming man. But, when it's time, he will speak up.

Before we explain about 1972, let's look in on the "usual" Johnny Miller. His retirement. His religious and helpful ways. And his memories about past NAIA basketball tournaments. You see, Johnny and his wife, Ovara, have witnessed twenty five consecutive NAIA tournaments. They were there Monday night for the finals-in their usual front-row seats at Kemper. Quiet, faithful, loyal.

ATTEND NAIA TOURNAMENT FOR 25 YEARS . . . Pee Wee Summers, Big Eight Official, and Krea State Farm Agent, stops by to chat with Johnny and Ovara Miller. The Millers have been attending the NAIA tournament for 25 years and their memories are featured in this week's Monday Night Footballer's column.

Retired Last May

That's Johnny Miller for you. Quiet and steady. Why, just last May he retired from the General Motors Assembly Plant at Leeds. There he drove a tractor, supplying the car assembly workers, to keep the line moving. They say he hardly missed a day in his 28 years there.

Raised in East Texas

And, as his smile widens a little, he talks a little about his garden. Mustard and turnip greens are his favorite. All that stems from his upbringing back in Henderson, Texas. A pretty good athlete himself, Johnny played first base in baseball and center in basketball. His quiet-like manner and his six-foot one frame helped him along.

But, life back there was different from the one here in Kansas. But, Johnny still has a deep, religious desire to help people just like back in East Texas.

And he keeps that belief alive, helping the elderly by painting and repairing items. And, he and his wife have been loyal members of the West Paseo Christian and Swope Parkway United Christian church for 32 years. Quietly, faithfully, always there.

Saw A Lot of Tournament Changes

And, just like the rest of his life, Johnny Miller mostly listens. But, as he talked about the many

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changes over the 52 years of the tournament, he focuses. His eyes tell you he knows. And he know he knows, too.

He knows he liked ol' Municipal Auditorium better than Kemper. It was a better and closer atmosphere for basketball. And, he speaks more confidently, as he remembers when the teams were either all black or all white. Either way, for 25 years, Johnny has come to these all-day and all-night games—with the same quiet way.

But, Monday night, he's up for talking. He quickens the pace when he talks about the NAIA alumni who have gone on to the National Basketball Association. Willis Reed, Earl "The Pearl" Monroe. Yes, he knows these were the best players up till 1972.

An Armchair Historian

And, now Johnny is talking more confidently than ever, as he tosses that quiet-like manner aside. Now, he's talking about Travis Grant of Kentucky State. That night, in 1972, against Minot State, Grant scored a record high sixty points, hitting twenty seven field goals.

And Johnny Miller was there. He tells you that, with an I'm-for-sure smile. He knows that Grants' performance that night could well have been the most outstanding individual performance ever in the history of the March tournament. And, it all happened down at the ol' Municipal auditorium. And without a three-point line.

Finally, Spoke Up

So, Johnny Miller talked up Monday night. Except this time, someone listened to him and asked him what happened. He was there. He saw. He remembered.

And tonight he spoke up. Like so many other older black folks, Johnny is an armchair sports historian, who quietly goes about his way. Never being asked. Never being heard.

But, Monday night at the 1989 championship game, the real Johnny Miller spoke up.

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